

GUARDIANS

of the goal

A closer look at the **goalkeepers and defenders** to watch out for this edition.

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Emiliano Martinez will arrive at the 2026 World Cup as one of the few modern-day goalkeepers who can claim to have shaped a previous edition, not merely survived it. Qatar 2022 was his World Cup debut, but he finished

it as a central figure in Argentina's third title — winning the Golden Glove and producing several defining moments, from the shootout saves against the Netherlands to the last-gasp stop from Randal Kolo Muani in the final, before denying Kingsley Coman from the spot.

Argentina sealed qualification for 2026 early last year and travel to North America as both defending world champion and 2024 Copa America winner, with Martinez again claiming the Golden Glove. More than a big-game personality, he has now become the team's security blanket.

At club level, his rise mirrors Aston Villa's. Since 2020, he has grown into one of Unai Emery's key figures, helping the club reach the 2024-25 Champions League quarterfinal and secure three straight seasons of European football. He also claimed the Premier League Save of the Season for 2024-25 and won the Lev Yashin Trophy in 2023 and 2024.

Emi Martinez

ARGENTINA

Age - 33

Club - Aston Villa

Int. caps - 59